

Chapter 64_2: Compliance

Li Chao'an swung the treasured sword in her hand, forcefully slashing at a patch of dark forest. More than ten trees were cut in half, crashing down with loud crashes and startling a flock of birds. She leaped up again and executed a sword flourish, her immortal power accompanied by crackling lightning heading toward another section of forest. But suddenly, another flash of lightning lit up from within the woods.

That force was so powerful that it completely swallowed her immortal power. An earth-shaking noise exploded in her ears, and Li Chao'an immediately sobered from her drunkenness, breaking out in cold sweat.

"Who's there!" She held her sword with trembling hands. A thunderclap responded to her voice, white light illuminating the forest and revealing a massive shadow several people tall within the woods.

Li Chao'an was so frightened her legs went weak. She turned and screamed as she fled toward Cloud Deep Hall¹, but her feet suddenly slipped. Tree vines wrapped around her ankle and dragged her toward the forest. She screamed desperately, her fingernails digging deep into the mud, leaving several deep furrows.

"Help! Help!" She cried with snot and tears streaming down her face. Then that person merely snapped their fingers, and her voice completely disappeared, leaving only hoarse gasping.

"Shh." That person spoke, their voice like a corpse dead for many years, making one's hair stand on end. A tree vine swayed and raised its head from among the woods, winding like a snake to Li Chao'an's front, gently tapping her forehead.

Li Chao'an's gaze changed from terror to emptiness, as if her soul had been extracted, becoming vacant.

"I heard hatred." The corpse-like voice sounded, and the vine slid down the woman's cheek, landing on her heart. The sound of piercing flesh rang out, and Li Chao'an's body began to convulse until that vine completely burrowed into her body.

"People persist, hatred never ceases. The incompetent can only complain day after day, lamenting their own suffering." That person's voice came from the dense forest, seeming to contain laughter that made listeners' hair stand on end. "Since you hate to the bone, why do you shrink back and hesitate?"

Li Chao'an opened and closed her mouth, her voice also becoming hoarse: "She doesn't deserve to have all this. I want her cut into a thousand pieces! I want her to be betrayed by everyone!"

"The child can be taught²." The corpse-like voice came again, then the vine dragging her leg silently retreated into the dense forest. A flower fairy that had been burned by lightning fell from mid-air to the ground, its body turning to ash.

The surrounding barrier disappeared, and the forest became empty again.

Wind suddenly rose, layers of clouds dispersed, revealing a crescent moon.

Li Chao'an lay on the ground for a moment before her gaze returned to normal. She stood up from the ground, her hands and feet light, slowly walking down the mountain.

This night saw many people tossing and turning. Someone sat by the window clutching a bracelet, listening to the wind all night. Someone hugged Ping An³ rolling on the bed, staring at the coffered ceiling all night.

Until dawn light appeared on the horizon, Ning Fuyi still hadn't fallen asleep. She pushed Ping An, who was sleeping like the dead, off the bed and got up with disheveled hair.

She sat on the bed meditating and cultivating for half a day, and only then did her heart calm down considerably. So she changed clothes and got up. As soon as she went out, she encountered a wooden bird used for transmitting messages. When opened, it carried Chu Qingqiu's calm voice: "Urgent matter in the Eastern Wasteland⁴. I have already left. Will return in two days."

When did Chu Qingqiu learn Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's⁵ message transmission method? Ning Fuyi reached out to touch the wooden bird, which then turned around and flew away crookedly.

Although she didn't know why Chu Qingqiu still needed to notify her, since her rebirth she had indeed rarely been separated from Chu Qingqiu. Now hearing that she had gone alone to the distant Eastern Wasteland, her heart felt somewhat strange.

She had just sent away the wooden bird when she suddenly discovered a pale pink butterfly in the corner of the wall. The butterfly's wings were half burned, barely alive as it rested outside the window.

Why would a butterfly be burned? Ning Fuyi approached with confusion, but unexpectedly, when the butterfly saw her coming, it actually wobbled and flew up, circling once in front of her before flying toward the outside of Pearl Light Pavilion⁶.

Ning Fuyi keenly sensed something was wrong and quickly followed. The butterfly flew unsteadily all the way, finally stopping on a very ordinary small path.

This path wasn't a main road, but a small path connecting Pearl Light Pavilion and Cloud Deep Hall. Disciples often passed through here to save effort. Ning Fuyi used her divine consciousness to investigate for a long time but didn't see anything unusual, so she walked into the woods.

Many trees were broken in the forest. Looking at the cuts, they had just been broken yesterday, severed by spirit swords. It should have been some disciple who accidentally damaged them while practicing. Ning Fuyi circled around without seeing anything strange. Just as she turned to leave, she caught sight of a flash of pink light on the ground.

She immediately crouched down to look closely and saw that the soil there was different from elsewhere, as if something had been burned. The glowing thing was a thin membrane, like...

Butterfly wing??

Ning Fuyi's heartstrings immediately tightened. Wasn't this the flower fairy she had sent out yesterday? Li Chao'an's cultivation level couldn't detect such spirits. How could the flower fairy have been burned to death in the woods?

She didn't delay any longer and quickly got up. However, she accidentally tripped on a vine exposed above ground. She stared at the vine fixedly, a thought crossing her phoenix eyes.

Then she turned and leaped onto Xiangsi⁷ to rush to Elder Pingyao's residence. Halfway there, she encountered Rong Jin, who was also flying on his sword. Seeing her hurried expression, he changed direction and followed behind her.

"Fuyi, where are you going?" he asked.

"Looking for Li Chao'an." Ning Fuyi said urgently, but then heard Rong Jin say something that nearly made her fall off Xiangsi.

"Li Chao'an went down the mountain to subdue demons this morning, together with Wenzhu." Rong Jin said in surprise.

Footnotes:

¹ **Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿)** - A main hall at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate where sect gatherings are held

² **The child can be taught (孺子可教)** - Chinese idiom meaning someone shows promise and can be educated or guided

³ **Ping An (平安)** - Ning Fuyi's pet, whose name means "peace" or "safety"

⁴ **Eastern Wasteland (东荒)** - A geographical region in the cultivation world, typically referring to barren eastern territories

⁵ **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)** - The name of the cultivation sect where the story takes place

⁶ **Pearl Light Pavilion (珠光阁)** - One of the residential buildings at the sect where disciples live

⁷ **Xiangsi (相思)** - The name of Ning Fuyi's divine sword, literally meaning "mutual longing" or "lovesickness"